

Photograph by **BANDEEP SINGH**

BOLD & BRAVE

KHELO INDIA

2,700
ATHLETES

Given training and financial support under Khelo India since its launch in 2017

- **National Anti-Doping Bill, 2021, passed**

BUT...

- **The National Youth Policy, 2021, is yet to be passed**
- **The wrestlers' as-yet futile protest and charges against WFI chief dent India's image**

YOUTH AFFAIRS & SPORTS

Upping the Game

Several government schemes seek to harness the potential of the youth but sports bodies need to be run professionally

By Kaushik Deka

INDIA'S POTENTIAL in sports is perhaps best measured in kilotonnes, given that it has the world's largest population in the 15-24 age bracket—around 254 million, as presently estimated by the United Nations Population Fund. But it still lies largely buried, like an untapped goldmine. That analogy applies equally well to everything else the young can get up to, as India struggles to cash in on this golden period. The objective of the Department of Youth Affairs (DoYA), led by Anurag Thakur, is to act as a facilitator to harness the power of this young demographic in fruitful ways. Its flagship schemes, training institutes and events are oriented to this end. In the last three years, the DoYA has also mobilised young men and women to be Covid warriors and take part in the Swachh Bharat Abhiyan and Clean India (Elimination of Single-use Plastic) campaigns.

Now, India's G20 presidency gives the DoYA a platform to amplify its efforts with the Youth20 engagement group. In the run-up to the main Y20 summit, it has been holding Y20 consultations at various universities—offering a chance to India's youth to link up with global causes and debates.

Sports has already started registering such an arc. In recent years, Indian sportspersons have been earning some hard-won global esteem—and medals—at the Commonwealth Games, Asian Games, Olympics and other big sports events. The Department of Sports has played an enabling role here, with schemes such as TOPS (Target Olympic Podium Scheme), Khelo India, training centres under the Sports Authority of India, awards and forms of assistance.

At the same time, the state of sports administration in India isn't exactly pretty. Across disciplines, federations have been mired in controversies over malpractices and political capture. The coup de grace, of course, is what dominates headlines these days: India's top wrestlers having to take to the streets to demand action against Brij Bhushan Sharan Singh, ruling party MP and wrestling federation chief, for alleged sexual harassment. No Y20 will cover up for the dent it causes to India's image. ■